

Massachusetts Rent Control Initiative (2026)

Overview

How would the ballot initiative have affected rent control policy in Massachusetts?

See also: [Text of measure](#)

The ballot initiative would have established rent control in Massachusetts, limiting annual rent increases for residential units to the Consumer Price Index (CPI) or 5%, whichever is lower.^[1] The annual rent increase limit would have been in place whether or not there was a change in tenancy in the rental unit.^[1]

The initiative stated that the rent amount in place on January 31, 2026, would have been the base rent on which annual increases are calculated; if the unit was vacant on that date, the most previously used rental price would have served as the base rent.^[1]

The following units would have been exempt from the rent increase limit:^[1]

- owner-occupied buildings with fewer than 5 units;
- facilities where rent is subject to regulation by other public authorities (though not including those occupied by a tenant with a mobile housing voucher);
- dwelling units rented primarily to transient guests for less than 14 consecutive days;
- facilities operated only for educational, religious, or nonprofit purposes; and
- dwelling units with a date of first occupancy that is less than 10 years old.

Text of measure

Full text

The full text of the ballot measure is available [here](#).

Support



Homes for All Massachusetts and Keep Massachusetts Home led the campaign in support of the initiative. ^[2]^[3]

Supporters

Officials

- Boston Mayor [Michelle Wu](#) (Nonpartisan)

Unions

- 1199 SEIU United Healthcare Workers East
- Asian American Resource Workshop
- Boston Teachers Union
- Local 509 SEIU
- Massachusetts Teachers Association
- SEIU Massachusetts State Council

Organizations

- Brockton Workers Alliance
- Chinese Progressive Association
- Coalition for Social Justice
- Community Action Agency of Somerville
- La Colaborativa
- Massachusetts Law Reform Institute
- Merrimack Valley Project
- New England Community Project
- Reclaim Roxbury
- Resist Inc.
- Springfield No One Leaves
- United Interfaith Action of Southeastern Massachusetts
- Urban Revival Inc.

Arguments

- **Noemi Ramos, executive director of New England Community Project:** "We know that corporate real estate lobbyists will say anything to protect their ability to double rents overnight, and we've already had tens of thousands of conversations with voters across the state to get ahead of their misinformation, and talk about how rent stabilization will stabilize our communities, protect our essential workers, and keep rent costs reasonable and predictable so that renters can save and have a fair shot at the dream of owning a home."
- **Homes for All Massachusetts:** "Designed with input from residents and experts across Massachusetts, this modern rent stabilization policy will protect tenants from big corporate investors who unreasonably increase rents, while allowing local landlords to earn a reasonable profit and enabling new construction to address housing shortages."
- **Rose Webster-Smith, director of Springfield No One Leaves:** "Working class and middle class people who do the jobs that keep our state going should be able to afford a roof over our heads. But right now, out-of-control housing costs are making it impossible for hundreds of thousands of families in Massachusetts to make ends meet. We need rent stabilization to keep rent costs reasonable and predictable, so that renters can save and have a fair shot at the dream of owning a home."
- **David Foley, president of SEIU Local 509:** "We represent a lot of workers who make \$20 or \$21 an hour, and everyone feels the same crunch if they rent right

now. Whatever wages the union is able to win at the bargaining table, those raises are almost always eaten up by huge rent increases."

- **Mark Martinez, staff housing attorney for the Massachusetts Law Reform Institute:** "This isn't a development policy. This is a stabilization policy. Judging a stabilization policy based off of whether or not it's going to spur development doesn't make a whole lot of sense."

Opposition



Housing for Massachusetts led the campaign in opposition to the initiative.^[4]

Opponents

Officials

- Gov. [Maura Healey](#) (D)
- Speaker of the House [Ronald Mariano](#) (D)
- Methuen Mayor [David Beauregard Jr.](#)
- Lawrence Mayor [Brian DePeña](#)
- Holyoke Mayor [Joshua Garcia](#)
- Agawam Mayor [Christopher Johnson](#)
- Revere Mayor [Patrick Keefe Jr.](#)
- Quincy Mayor [Thomas Koch](#)
- Leominster Mayor [Dean Mazzarella](#)
- New Bedford Mayor [Jon Mitchell](#)
- Gardner Mayor [Michael Nicholson](#) (D)
- Worcester Mayor [Joseph Petty](#)

Corporations

- Masslandlords Inc.
- Nordblom Management Co.

Organizations

- Associated Industries of Massachusetts (AIM)
- Greater Boston Real Estate Board
- Massachusetts Association of REALTORS
- Massachusetts Biotechnology Council
- Massachusetts Business Roundtable
- Massachusetts Fiscal Alliance
- NAIOP Massachusetts
- Small Property Owners Association

Arguments

- **Governor Maura Healey (D):** "Investors in housing have already pulled out of Massachusetts because they're concerned about rent control. I don't want to see housing production stopped."
- **Tony Lopes with the Small Property Owners Association:** "[The initiative] penalizes the small property owners who make up 60% or more of [the] commonwealth's rental market, including the immigrant and minority property owners who are seeking just to get ahead. We need to consider real solutions, zoning reform, more state-level housing production, and accountability for the rising cost of insurance."
- **Greg Vasil, CEO of the Greater Boston Real Estate Board, Theresa Hatton, CEO of the Massachusetts Association of Realtors, and Tamara Small, CEO of NAIOP Massachusetts:** "The risks of this ballot question for our economy cannot be overstated. It is not an opt-in: this question creates the most restrictive rent control program in the entire United States and forces it on every city and town across the Commonwealth. It will unquestionably make our housing crisis worse and significantly reduce the supply of quality homes on the rental market."
- **Paul Diego Craney, executive director for the Massachusetts Fiscal Alliance:** "Whenever government imposes price controls, the costs always get shifted elsewhere, in this case, onto homeowners, it's a tax hike disguised as housing relief that will ultimately lead to increased costs for everyone."

- **Tamara Small, CEO of the NAIOP of Massachusetts:** "If rent control is in place in the market, investors do not go to that market. They go elsewhere. Without those investment dollars, projects are not built."
- **Board members of the Massachusetts Housing Coalition, Steve Callahan Jr., Neily Soto, and Peggy Pratt:** "Massachusetts voters overwhelmingly banned rent control statewide in 1994 after experiencing its negative effects in communities like Boston, Cambridge, and Brookline. Rental properties under rate caps experienced deferred maintenance, reduced quality, while communities saw a noticeable drop in new rental development. When controls were lifted, housing production rebounded, and the market began adding units again. It's not by accident, either: When property owners and developers have confidence in the state's commitment to housing production across all income levels, they historically make continued investment in local communities."
- **Housing for Massachusetts:** "Rent control will impact everyone – not just rent controlled units. A recent study from the Center for State Policy Analysis at Tufts University found that rent control would almost immediately shrink the residential property tax base by 6–9% across Massachusetts municipalities. Over a decade, property values could fall by nearly 14%, costing homeowners roughly \$300 billion. Cities and towns would be forced to choose between deep cuts to services or tax hikes of at least 10% to compensate. Urban areas and college towns would be hit especially hard, with projected declines of 15–20%. Even homeowners with no rental units would feel the impact through higher taxes, reduced services, and a long-term loss of investment in their communities."
- **New Bedford Mayor Jon Mitchell (D):** "What is especially ominous about the proposed ballot question is that it applies not just to the red-hot Boston housing market, but everywhere else in the Commonwealth. In Greater New Bedford and other regions where housing developers at times struggle to make their numbers work, it would effectively shut down housing production."
- **Small Property Owners Association President Amir Shahsavari:** "When you have a policy where rents would be capped at 5% or CPI, whichever is lower — and CPI is typically somewhere in the 2-2.5% range — that's not enough for us to keep up with expenses, and therefore housing falls into disrepair and problems ensue for both tenants, owners and other stakeholders."

Campaign finance

See also: [Ballot measure campaign finance, 2026](#)

The campaign finance information on this page reflects the most recent scheduled reports that Ballotpedia has processed, which covered through **January 20, 2026**. The deadline for the next scheduled reports is **September 4, 2026**.

Keep Massachusetts Home registered as the committee in support of the initiative.

Housing for Massachusetts registered as the committee in opposition to the initiative.^[5]



	Cash Contributions	In-Kind Contributions	Total Contributions	Cash Expenditures	Total Expenditures
Support	\$57,721.88	\$689,980.55	\$747,702.43	\$17,784.07	\$707,764.62
Oppose	\$431,600.00	\$26,634.30	\$458,234.30	\$0.00	\$26,634.30
Total	\$489,321.88	\$716,614.85	\$1,205,936.73	\$17,784.07	\$734,398.92

Support

The following table includes contribution and expenditure totals for the committees in support of the measure.^[5]

Committees in support of Rent Control Initiative					
Committee	Cash Contributions	In-Kind Contributions	Total Contributions	Cash Expenditures	Total Expenditures
Keep Massachusetts Home	\$57,721.88	\$689,980.55	\$747,702.43	\$17,784.07	\$707,764.62
Total	\$57,721.88	\$689,980.55	\$747,702.43	\$17,784.07	\$707,764.62

Donors

The following were the top donors who contributed to the support committees.^[5]

Donor	Cash Contributions	In-Kind Contributions	Total Contributions
Urban Revival Inc	\$0.00	\$203,341.31	\$203,341.31
Right to the City Alliance Inc.	\$0.00	\$136,580.98	\$136,580.98
ew England Community Project	\$0.00	\$54,987.42	\$54,987.42
Tides Advocacy	\$0.00	\$34,415.77	\$34,415.77
La Colaborativa	\$0.00	\$33,443.90	\$33,443.90

Opposition

The following table includes contribution and expenditure totals for the committees in opposition to the measure.^[5]

Committees in opposition to Rent Control Initiative					
Committee	Cash Contributions	In-Kind Contributions	Total Contributions	Cash Expenditures	Total Expenditures
Housing for Massachusetts	\$431,600.00	\$26,634.30	\$458,234.30	\$0.00	\$26,634.30
Total	\$431,600.00	\$26,634.30	\$458,234.30	\$0.00	\$26,634.30

Donors

The following were the top donors who contributed to the opposition committees.^[5]



Donor	Cash Contributions	In-Kind Contributions	Total Contributions
NAIOP Massachusetts	\$226,600.00	\$0.00	\$226,600.00

Greater Boston Real Estate Board Operating Account	\$100,000.00	\$0.00	\$100,000.00
Massachusetts Association of Realtos	\$55,000.00	\$0.00	\$55,000.00
Nordblom Managment Co. Inc	\$50,000.00	\$0.00	\$50,000.00
Masslandlords, Inc.	\$0.00	\$26,634.30	\$26,634.30

Methodology

To read Ballotpedia's methodology for covering ballot measure campaign finance information, [click here](#).

Polls

See also: [Ballotpedia's approach to covering polls](#) and [2026 ballot measure polls](#)

Poll	Dates	Sample size	Margin of error	Support	Oppose	Undecided
Polity Research Consulting	April 29, 2026–May 7, 2026	608	±3.	69.0%	19.0%	12.0%

				97		
				%		
University of New Hampshire Survey Center Question	April 16, 2026–April 20, 2026	60 1 LV	± 3. 60 %	57. 0%	27 .0 %	17.0 %
University of New Hampshire Survey Center Question	Feb. 12, 2026–Feb. 16, 2026	66 9 Resident s	± 3. 80 %	56. 0%	26 .0 %	17.0 %
Suffolk University Political Research Center/The Boston Globe Question	Nov. 19, 2025–Nov. 23, 2025	50 0 RV	± 4. 40 %	62. 6%	30 .6 %	6.8%

Note: LV is likely voters, RV is registered voters, and EV is eligible voters.

Background

Question 9 (1994)

In 1994, Massachusetts voters decided [Question 9](#), which repealed existing rent control laws and prohibited any future rent control laws. Voters approved the measure, with 51.3% voting yes.



The measure allowed cities and towns to adopt a restricted form of rent control for a period of six months or less, after which compliance with the rent control policy would be optional.^[6] Question 9 did not affect the rent control policies for publicly owned or subsidized housing, federally assisted housing, or mobile homes.^[6]

Local Governance of Rental Properties Initiative (2024)

In 2023, state Rep. [Mike Connolly](#) (D-26th Middlesex) filed a [ballot initiative](#) with the state of Massachusetts that would have permitted cities and towns to set their own rent control and residential eviction laws.^[7] About the initiative, Connolly said, "Many people assume there are some rules. Many people assume that, well, a landlord couldn't just say 'I'm going to double your rent' or 'I'm not going to extend your lease' for no reason. People need to understand [there] are truly no rules when it comes to rent or evictions, in many respects."^[8]

The initiative did not have the support of most labor unions or housing coalitions in Massachusetts.^[9] Homes for All Massachusetts made a statement on Connolly's initiative. They said, "We have serious concerns about Representative Connolly's unilateral decision to move forward on a 2024 ballot question against the wishes of movement leaders, and without collaborating with the statewide anti-eviction and anti-foreclosure coalition."^[10] They asked Connolly to stop the campaign for the initiative, saying ""We ask Representative Connolly to drop his effort to pursue a rent control ballot question campaign, which will detract from the effort to win the policies our communities need and is not supported by the vast majority of rent control advocates."^[9]

The initiative was approved to begin gathering signatures, but in November 2025, a few weeks before the signature submission deadline, the campaign announced it was suspending its signature gathering efforts.^[11] The initiative was not placed on the ballot.

Carolyn Chou, the director of Homes for All Massachusetts, made a statement after it was announced the initiative would not be on the 2024 ballot. She said, "We are committed to winning rent control in the next few years. To us, that means continuing to put the legislative strategy through this session, and if needed, next session — and if we can't win at the Legislature this time, to have the ballot initiative as part of that strategy."^[11]

Rent control in the state legislature, 2023-2025

In 2023, state Sen. [Patricia Jehlen](#) (D-2nd Middlesex) introduced Senate Bill 1299, which would have enabled cities and towns to pass rent control laws in Massachusetts.^[12] The bill was considered and read in the state legislature multiple times over the two-year legislative session, but it was never passed by either chamber.

In 2025, legislators in the state House and Senate introduced Senate Bill 1447 and House Bill 2328.^{[13][14]} Both bills would have enabled cities and towns to pass rent control laws. Neither bill was approved by either chamber of the state legislature.

Rent control ballot measures in other states

See also: [Rent control and regulations ballot measures](#)

Aside from Massachusetts, California is the only other state that has decided the issue of rent control by ballot measure. Between 1996 and 2024, California voters decided five statewide ballot measures on rent control and regulations.



- [Proposition 199 \(1996\)](#): Would have prohibited rent control on mobile homes and required mobile home park owners to offer subsidies for low-income owners.
- [Proposition 98 \(2008\)](#): Would have prohibited future rent control measures and phased out prior rent control measures.
- [Proposition 10 \(2018\)](#): Would have allowed local governments to adopt rent control policies and repealed the [Costa-Hawkins Rental Housing Act](#).
- [Proposition 21 \(2020\)](#): Would have allowed rent control policies for housing that was first occupied before 2005, with some exceptions.
- [Proposition 33 \(2024\)](#): Would have repealed the [Costa-Hawkins Rental Housing Act](#) and allowed local governments to implement rent control policies.

All five of the measures were defeated by voters. [Proposition 10](#), in 2018, was approved by the largest percentage of voters; 40.6% of voters approved the measure.

Path to the ballot

Process in Massachusetts

See also: [Laws governing the initiative process in Massachusetts](#)

An **indirect initiated state statute** is a [citizen-initiated ballot measure](#) that amends state statute. There are nine (9) states that allow citizens to initiate indirect state statutes.

While a direct initiative is placed on the ballot once supporters file the required number of valid signatures, an indirect initiative is first presented to the state legislature. Legislators have a certain number of days, depending on the state, to adopt the initiative into law. Should legislators take no action or reject the initiative, the initiative is put on the ballot for voters to decide.

In Massachusetts, the [number of signatures required](#) for an indirect initiated state statute is equal to 3% of the votes cast in the last gubernatorial election. Massachusetts also has a [distribution requirement](#) that requires no more than 25% of the certified signatures on any petition can come from a single county.

The [state Legislature](#) has until the first Wednesday of May in the election year to pass the statute. If the legislature does not pass the proposed statute, proponents must collect a second round of signatures equal to 0.5% of the votes cast in the last gubernatorial election. The Legislature also has the power to place an alternative measure alongside the proposed statute via a simple majority vote of the state legislature.

A simple majority vote is required for voter approval. However, the number of affirmative votes cast for the measure must be greater than 30% of the votes cast in the election.

The requirements to get an initiated state statute certified for the 2026 ballot:

- **Signatures (first round):** 74,574
- **Signatures (second round):** 12,429
- **Deadline (first round):** The deadline to submit the first round of signatures to the secretary of state was December 3, 2025.
- **Deadline (second round):** The deadline to submit the second round of signatures is July 1, 2026.

Stages of the ballot initiative

The following is the timeline of the initiative.^[15]



- August 7, 2025: The Massachusetts Attorney General announced that the initiative had been filed.
- September 3, 2025: The Massachusetts Attorney General announced that the initiative had been cleared and that supporters could begin gathering signatures for the initiative.
- November 19, 2025: Home for All Massachusetts announced the collected and submitted more than 124,000 signatures in support of the initiative.^[16]
- December 18, 2025: The state Elections Division announced that it had certified 88,132 valid signatures in support of the initiative. As such, it was certified to go before the state legislature in the 2026 legislative session.^[17]
- February 5, 2026: The initiative was introduced to the Massachusetts General Court as House Bill 5008 (H. 5008).^[18]
- May 5, 2026: As of this date, the deadline for legislative action on the measure, the Massachusetts General Court had not approved the initiative. As such, the second round of signature collection began.
- June 2, 2026: Homes for All Massachusetts announced they had drafted a potential legislative compromise on the initiative. Carolyn Chou, executive director of Homes for All Massachusetts, stated that, "While we made significant concessions in an effort to reach a true compromise, this legislation would achieve our primary goals of ending the state's ban on rent control and enabling strong protections from excessive rent hikes and unjust evictions for Massachusetts residents."^[19] She said, "[W]e have agreed to not move forward with the ballot measure if this compromise language is passed by July 1."^[19]
- June 16, 2026: Both Gov. [Maura Healey](#) (D) and NAIOP Massachusetts announced that they would support a compromise on rent control to avoid placing the ballot measure on the November 2026 ballot.^{[20][21]}
- June 23, 2026: The Massachusetts Supreme Court ruled that the measure could not be placed on the November 2026 ballot because it improperly concerned religious issues.^[22]

Arcangelo Cella et. al. v. Attorney General et. al.

Arcangelo Cella et. al. v. Attorney General et. al.

Measure blocked from the November 2026 ballot on June 24, 2026

Court Information

Issue	Does the ballot measures comply with the requirements included in the state constitution?
Court	Massachusetts Supreme Court

Ruling

Ruling	The measure provides for an exception for units in religious facilities, which is contrary to the Massachusetts Constitution which prohibits a measure concerning religion from being proposed as an initiative petition.
Order(s)	Order: Massachusetts Supreme Court (June 23, 2026)

Participants

Plaintiff(s)	Arcangelo Cella, Teresa Del Singore, Katherine Horey, and Susan M. Renfrew
Defendant(s)	Andrea J. Campbell and William F. Galvin



On February 6, 2026, a group of property owners in Massachusetts filed a lawsuit with the Supreme Judicial Court in Suffolk County challenging the initiative. The lawsuit stated that the initiative violates the requirements for ballot measures in the state constitution and that the Attorney General's summary of the initiative improperly represents the initiative.^{[23][24]}

On June 24, 2026, the Massachusetts Supreme Court ruled that the measure could not be placed on the ballot because it would have exempted units in religious facilities. Justice [Frank Gaziano](#) reported the court's ruling. His written statement said, "by including an express exemption for facilities operated solely for religious purposes, the petition impermissibly makes religion 'a factor in [the petition's] application.'"^[25]

Article 48 of the Massachusetts Constitution states, "No measure that relates to religion, religious practices or religious institutions," can be proposed by an initiative petition.^[26]

Noemi Ramos, chair of the Keep Massachusetts Home campaign, said the ruling was a disappointment not the end of the campaign for rent control in Massachusetts.^[27] She said, "Rather than accept any restrictions on their ability to extract profits from our communities, a few private equity-backed real estate investment corporations financed this lawsuit in a desperate attempt to avoid a ballot campaign they were set to lose."^[27]

Conor Yunits, spokesperson for Housing for Massachusetts, said of the ruling, "While we firmly believe that Massachusetts voters were prepared to vote 'no' in November, today's decision puts the issue to rest and protects our housing pipeline and our communities from the proven damage that rent control inflicts."^[22]

External links

- [Massachusetts Ballot Initiatives Submitted for the 2026 Election and 2028 Election](#)

See also

2026 ballot measures

View other measures certified for the 2026 ballot across the U.S. and in Massachusetts.

- [2026 ballot measures](#)
- [Massachusetts 2026 ballot measures](#)

- [Massachusetts elections, 2026](#)

Massachusetts ballot measures

Explore Massachusetts's ballot measure history, including citizen-initiated ballot measures.

- [List of Massachusetts ballot measures](#)
- [Massachusetts Historical Ballot Measures Factbook](#)
- [Rent control and regulations ballot measures](#)
- [Massachusetts State Legislature](#)

Initiative process

Understand how measures are placed on the ballot and the rules that apply.

- [Laws governing the initiative process in Massachusetts](#)
- [Initiated state statute](#)
- [Massachusetts Constitution](#)



Footnotes

1. [Ballot Initiatives Submitted for the 2026 Biennial Statewide Election \(proposed laws\) and 2026 Biennial Statewide Election \(proposed constitutional amendments\)](#), "An Initiative Petition to Protect Tenants by Limiting Rent Increases," accessed August 7, 2025
2. [Homes for All Massachusetts](#), "Homepage," accessed December 19, 2025
3. [Keep Massachusetts Home](#), "Homepage," accessed December 19, 2025
4. [Housing for Massachusetts](#), "What is Rent Control," accessed April 7, 2026
5. [Massachusetts OCPF](#), "Active Ballot Question Committee Reports," accessed May 28, 2026
6. [Massachusetts Elections](#), "1994 Election Results," accessed December 19, 2025
7. [Mass.gov](#), "Ballot Initiatives filed for the 2024 Biennial Statewide Election (proposed laws) and 2026 Biennial Statewide Election (proposed constitutional amendments)," accessed December 19, 2025
8. [GBH](#), "Why Rep. Mike Connolly is petitioning to get rent control on the 2024 ballot," accessed December 19, 2025

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10. *Boston Globe*, "As progressives split on rent control tactics, ballot campaign pushes ahead," accessed December 19, 2025
11. *Boston Globe*, "Connolly suspending campaign to put rent control on statewide ballot," accessed November 13, 2023
12. *Massachusetts Legislature*, "Bill S. 1299," accessed December 19, 2025
13. *Massachusetts Legislature*, "Bill S. 1447," accessed December 19, 2025
14. *Massachusetts Legislature*, "Bill H. 2328," accessed December 19, 2025
15. *Mass.gov*, "Ballot Initiatives Submitted for the 2026 Biennial Statewide Election (proposed laws) and 2028 Biennial Statewide Election (proposed constitutional amendments)," accessed August 7, 2025
16. *CBS News*, "Rent control in Massachusetts? Supporters say they have enough signatures for ballot question.," accessed November 19, 2025
17. *Worcester Business Journal*, "Ballot initiative to recriminalize recreational cannabis sales receives certification," accessed December 19, 2025
18. *General Court of Massachusetts*, "An Act to protect tenants by limiting rent increases," accessed March 16, 2026
19. *Commonwealth Beacon*, "Rent control backers scrambling to find legislative road away from the ballot," accessed June 2, 2026
20. *MassLive*, "As momentum builds, Mass. Gov. Healey wants a compromise on rent control," accessed June 16, 2026
21. *CommonWealth Beacon*, "Powerful real estate group says it's open to rent control compromise," accessed June 17, 2026
22. *Boston Globe*, "As high court tosses out rent control ballot measure, tenant groups lose on Beacon Hill again," accessed June 24, 2026
23. *Commonwealth Beacon*, "Rent control opponents sue to keep measure off the ballot," accessed February 10, 2026
24. *Supreme Judicial Court for Suffolk County*, "Arcangelo Cella et. al. v. Andrea J. Campbell and William F. Galvin," accessed February 10, 2026
25. *Massachusetts Supreme Court*, "Arcangelo Cella et. al. v. Attorney General et. al.," accessed June 24, 2026
26. *General Court of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts*, "Massachusetts Constitution," accessed June 24, 2026
27. *Mass Live*, "Mass. Supreme Judicial Court tosses rent control ballot question over religious exemption," accessed June 24, 2026

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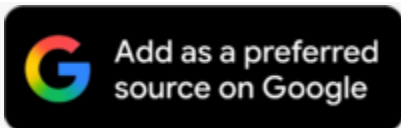
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